

Comparison and Contrast

CHAPTER WARM-UP



Using the cross-examining prewriting technique described on page 131, answer the questions in reference to two magazines you enjoy reading.

Often in your writing, you will need to discuss an object, idea, or item not in terms of its own features, but in terms of how it relates to another object, idea, or item. This type of writing can be a challenge because it forces you to think about each item on its own, as well as about the ways in which the items relate to one another. Are they alike? Are they different? How? Although you will often need to compare and contrast several items at one time in your writing, this chapter focuses on comparing and contrasting just two items, for the sake of simplicity.

Deciding to Compare or to Contrast

The two main tools you use in this type of writing are **comparison** and **contrast**. When you compare things, you are looking for similarities. When you contrast things, you are looking for differences. For example, consider two shirts. In comparing them, you might notice that they are both white, have collars, and have buttons. When contrasting them, you might notice that they are made of different materials, that only one has buttons on the collar, and that one is a dress shirt and the other is a casual shirt. Comparison and contrast, therefore, assists the reader in understanding one person, place, feeling, idea, or object in relation to another.

 PRACTICE 1

Comparing or Contrasting

Look at the following pairs of topics. Decide whether it would be better to compare or contrast each pair.

	<i>Compare</i>	<i>Contrast</i>
1. My friends Bob and Carl	_____	_____
2. Antarctica and the Sahara Desert	_____	_____
3. Concrete and rubber	_____	_____
4. Beef and fish	_____	_____
5. Internet search engines Yahoo! and Google	_____	_____
6. Idaho and Yukon Gold potatoes	_____	_____
7. French and California wines	_____	_____
8. Nurses and doctors	_____	_____
9. Jogging and walking	_____	_____
10. Apples and oranges	_____	_____

 PRACTICE 2

Comparing or Contrasting

Look at the following pairs of topics. Decide whether it would be better to compare or contrast each pair.

	<i>Compare</i>	<i>Contrast</i>
1. Board games Monopoly and Careers	_____	_____
2. Attorney and judge	_____	_____

- | | | |
|---|-------|-------|
| 3. Movie star and rock star | _____ | _____ |
| 4. Swimming in a pool or a lake | _____ | _____ |
| 5. Oral exam and essay exam | _____ | _____ |
| 6. Coin collecting and stamp collecting | _____ | _____ |
| 7. Canada and the United States | _____ | _____ |
| 8. Soccer and rugby | _____ | _____ |
| 9. Running shoes and walking shoes | _____ | _____ |
| 10. Chicago and New York style pizza | _____ | _____ |

The Topic Sentence

The comparison/contrast paragraph begins with a topic sentence that clearly states the two items being compared or contrasted and explains why comparing or contrasting them is important. Here is an example of a topic sentence for a comparison/contrast paragraph.

When parents choose between a two-year college and a four-year college for their child, cost is often a deciding factor.

This topic sentence clearly states the two items for comparison: two-year and four-year colleges. “Cost” is the factor mentioned that indicates how the writer is going to compare the two types of colleges.

The entire paragraph might look like this:

When parents choose between a two-year college and a four-year college for their child, cost is often a deciding factor. Tuition is a major cost when deciding on which college to attend. At a four-year college, tuition is a flat fee that can run anywhere from \$8,000 to \$40,000, depending on the size and selectivity of the school. The student can take from twenty-four to thirty-six credit hours per year, and the tuition charge will not vary. In addition to tuition costs, room and board adds to the expenses at the four-year college. Room and board can run from \$4,000 to \$15,000 per year, depending on the school’s dormitory and apartment facilities. Consequently, the cost for tuition and room and board at a four-year college can run between \$12,000 and \$55,000. Unlike four-year colleges, two-year colleges charge by the credit hour, usually ranging from \$37 to \$48 per credit hour; therefore, a student taking between twenty-four and thirty-six credit hours per year will pay between \$900 and \$1,800 per year in tuition. Another major difference between four-year and two-year colleges is that most two-year colleges do not have dormitories.

(continued)

They are known more as “commuter schools” because students live at home and drive to school each day. Because most families do not have to adjust their budgets for children who are going to college but still living at home as they did during high school, there is no “additional” cost for room and board. Even if parents charge room and board to their college student living at home, the charge is usually somewhat reduced, say \$200 per month. This would add an additional \$2,000 to the cost. Thus, the expense for a two-year college, including room and board and tuition, would be between \$900 and \$3,800 per year.

PRACTICE 3**Writing Compare and Contrast Topic Sentences**

Compose both comparison and contrasting topic sentences for the pairs of items listed below.

Example

Topic: Two Friends

- a. Julio and Angelina have very different study habits. (Contrast)
- b. Aretha and Maurice have similar exercise routines. (Comparison)

1. Two Musical Groups

- a. _____
- b. _____

2. Two Restaurants

- a. _____
- b. _____

3. Two School Courses

- a. _____
- b. _____

PRACTICE 4**Writing Compare and Contrast Topic Sentences**

Compose both comparison and contrasting topic sentences for the pairs of items listed below.

1. Two Vacation Spots/Resorts

- a. _____
- b. _____

2. Two Bosses

- a. _____
- b. _____

3. Two Types/Styles of Clothes

- a. _____
- b. _____

Organizing Comparisons and Contrasts

Once you know what comparisons and contrasts you are going to use, you need to organize your thoughts and decide how to present them. There are two commonly used organizational plans for comparison and contrast paragraphs: **block** and **point-by-point**. The block method presents information about one item first, then uses this information for comparison or contrast when presenting information about the second item in the second half of the paragraph. The point-by-point method presents the information about both items together, creating an ongoing series of comparisons and contrasts.

Block Method

In the preceding paragraph about two-year and four-year colleges, the block method is used. Notice that the cost elements of the four-year college are discussed in the first half of the paragraph (without mention of the two-year college). Afterward, the same cost elements concerning the two-year college are discussed in the second half of the paragraph.

The block method is illustrated in this manner:

Topic Sentence: When parents choose between a two-year college and a four-year college for their child, cost is often a deciding factor.

Block 1: Four-year college

- a. Tuition
- b. Room and board

Block 2: Two-year college

- a. Tuition
- b. Room and board

Remember, when using the block method, you discuss all the factors in the first item of comparison in the first part of the paragraph without mentioning the second item in the comparison. Then in the second half of the paragraph, discuss each point regarding the second item in the comparison, remembering to make reference to each item that was mentioned in the first half of the paragraph. This will connect the two items of the comparison so that the paragraph will not seem to be about two items that have nothing to do with one another.

Point-by-Point Method

In the point-by-point method, each point concerning each item being compared is followed by the similar point concerning the second item in the comparison. For example, in a paragraph comparing four-year and two-year colleges, as each cost element of the four-year college is mentioned, it is compared to the same cost element at the two-year college. In this way, the comparison between the elements is continually made.

The point-by-point method is illustrated in this manner:

Topic Sentence: When parents choose between a two-year college and a four-year college for their child, cost is often a deciding factor.

Point 1: Tuition

- a. Four-year college tuition
 - b. Two-year college tuition
- 

Point 2: Room and Board

- a. Four-year college room and board
 - b. Two-year college room and board
- 

Using the point-by-point method, the paragraph might be written like this:

When parents choose between a two-year college and a four-year college for their child, cost is often a deciding factor. Tuition is a major cost when deciding on which college to attend. At a four-year college, tuition is a flat fee that can run anywhere from \$8,000 to \$40,000 per year, depending on the size and selectivity of the school. The student can take from twenty-four to thirty-six credit hours per year, and the tuition charge will not vary. However, two-year colleges charge by the credit hour, usually ranging from \$37 to \$48 per credit; therefore, a student taking between twenty-four to thirty-six credit hours per year will pay between \$900 and \$1,800 per year in tuition. In addition to tuition costs, room and board adds to the expenses at the four-year college. Room and board can run from \$4,000 to \$15,000 per year, depending on the school's dormitory and apartment facilities. In contrast, most two-year colleges do not have dormitories. They are known more as "commuter schools" because students live at home and drive to school each day. Because most families do not have to adjust their budgets for children who are going to college but still living at home as they did during high school, there is no "additional" cost for room and board. Even if parents charge room and board to their college student living at home, the charge is usually somewhat reduced, say \$200 per month. This would add an additional \$2,000 to the cost. Thus, the expense for a two-year college, including room and board and tuition, would be between \$900 and \$3,800 per year.

Notice that in the point-by-point method, each item in the elements to be compared is developed in the same order. It is important to keep the order consistent to avoid confusion.



Transitional Expressions: Connecting Your Comparisons and Contrasts

Transitional expressions are important because they stress either comparison or contrast, depending on the type of paragraph you are writing.

Transitional Expressions Showing Comparison

again	just as
also	just like
and	like
as well as	likewise
both	neither
each	similarly
equally	similar to
furthermore	so
in addition	the same
in the same way	too

Transitional Expressions Showing Contrast

although	nevertheless
but	on the contrary
despite	on the other hand
different from	otherwise
even though	still
except for	though
however	whereas
in contrast	while
instead	yet

PRACTICE 5

Using Transitional Expressions Showing Contrast

The following paragraph is difficult to understand because of a lack of transitional expressions that stress *contrast*. On separate paper, add proper transitional expressions that show contrast. To achieve variety, do not use the same transitional expression more than once.

The United States has many historical places of interest. They are more modern than those in Mexico. The Statue of Liberty is barely a century old. The pyramids found in Tenochtitlán are at least a millennium old. Another

historic place to visit in the United States is Philadelphia, where many of the events of the American Revolution occurred. It is over two hundred years old. Guanajuato, in Mexico, is historic because many events of the Mexican Revolution happened there. Walking down Guanajuato's streets is just like going back in time. The houses and roads are four and five hundred years old. Many of the houses have been ravaged by time, and the ancient roads polished shiny by the winds of time.

PRACTICE 6 Using Transitional Expressions Showing Comparison

The following paragraph is difficult to understand because of a lack of transitional expressions that stress *comparison*. On separate paper, add proper transitional expressions that show comparison. To achieve variety, do not use the same transitional expression more than once.

The occupations of cosmetologist and nurse may seem very different, but they share many common attributes. The cosmetologist makes the client's appearance better by using the proper grooming techniques. The nurse uses the latest medical procedures when treating a patient. A cosmetologist's client often feels depressed or anxious about his or her appearance. By using the coloring products appropriate to the client's complexion and age, the cosmetologist can change a person's appearance dramatically, making people feel good about themselves once again. The nurse makes the patient feel better by administering the proper medications or exercise appropriate for the patient's problem and age group. Both the cosmetologist and the nurse make the people in their care feel better about themselves.

PRACTICE 7 Analyzing a Contrast Paragraph

In the following paragraph from an essay, "'The Jury' Is In!" student writer Carol Hoxworth contrasts two novels by popular writer John Grisham. Hoxworth focuses on character development as a crucial difference between the two stories.

In *The Runaway Jury*, the character development is superb because Grisham alludes to certain aspects of the characters' personalities throughout

the development of the plot. One of the strong points of this novel is being fed only enough information about them at the crucial time; therefore, a desire is created within the reader to know each character more intimately and how they will relate to the rest of the story. In contrast, *The Testament* has a glaring lack of character development from the very beginning of the novel. There is some confusion in the first few chapters as to who the main characters are. Instead of revealing the nature of each personality throughout the book, Grisham gives bland, generic, and brief descriptions of each. There also seems to be an overabundance of characters who truly are not necessary to the development and enrichment of the plot, so the desire to know the characters better and to see how the plot relates to them is not achieved.

Contrast Technique Questions

1. What is the writer contrasting in the paragraph? Is there a topic sentence that clearly states the items for contrast? If not, write one for the paragraph.

2. What organizational pattern does the writer use, point-by-point or block?

3. How does the writer make a smooth transition to the second part of the paragraph?

4. Does the writer use enough specific examples to develop and clarify the contrast?

PRACTICE 8**Analyzing a Comparison Paragraph**

In the following paragraph from an essay, “Commercial vs. Residential Real Estate,” student writer Nancy Smith compares two aspects of her job that on the surface might seem quite different but, in reality, are very similar.

Marketing costs for commercial real estate are paid for by the company; similarly, in residential real estate, costs are usually picked up by the company, as well. Like residential real estate, commercial real estate sends out thousands of flyers advertising property for lease or sale. For example, both commercial and residential agents mail advertising brochures to area residents and other agents announcing available properties. Both commercial and residential agents can work alone or share commissions with other agents when a property is sold, rented, or leased.

Comparison Technique Questions

1. What is the writer contrasting in the paragraph? Is there a topic sentence that clearly states the items for comparison? If not, write one for the paragraph.

2. What organizational pattern does the writer use, point-by-point or block?

3. How does the writer transition smoothly so that the points do not seem like merely a list of items strung together?

4. Does the writer use enough specific examples to develop and clarify the contrast?

PRACTICE 9 Analyzing a Contrast Paragraph

In the following paragraph from an essay, “Throughout the Years,” student writer Meghan Burrows contrasts the changing aspects of her relationship with her father as she grew from a young girl into an adolescent.

When I was little, Dad often was my coach for soccer, softball, volleyball, and basketball. If not the designated coach, he would be on the sidelines helping out. We used to play catch every evening before and after dinner. Going for a ride to Wal-Mart or to the car wash was always a treat. But as I grew older, being “Daddy’s Little Girl” wasn’t so easy; in fact, it became a source of distance between us. Going through adolescence isn’t easy for anyone, and I was no exception. The first time I remember feeling less close to my father was the day my body decided to take the plunge into womanhood. Because I felt scared and embarrassed, the last person whom I wanted to find out was my father. Needless to say, he found out. I think that was the day it came home to him that I was no longer going to be his little girl. As the next few years went by, I realized that I could make my own decisions. I could decide when to go to bed, when and what to eat, what clothes to wear, and what sports to play.

Contrast Technique Questions

1. What is the writer contrasting in the paragraph? Is there a topic sentence that clearly states the items for contrast? If not, write one for the paragraph.

2. What organizational pattern does the writer use, point-by-point or block?

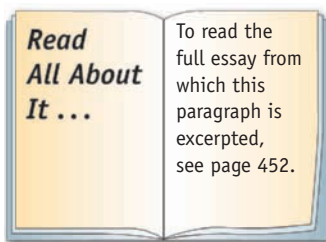
3. How does the writer transition smoothly from the first part of the paragraph to the second half of the paragraph so that the contrasting points are connected?

4. Does the writer use enough specific examples to develop and clarify the contrasts?

PRACTICE 10

Analyzing and Writing Comparison Paragraphs

In the following paragraph from an essay, “Grant and Lee: A Study in Contrasts,” professional historian Bruce Catton focuses on the differences between the two great Civil War generals. However, Catton does on occasion comment on the similarities between the two leaders.



Lastly, and perhaps greatest of all, there was the ability, at the end, to turn quickly from war to peace once the fighting was over. Out of the way these two men behaved at Appomattox came the possibility of a peace of reconciliation. It was a possibility not wholly realized, in the years to come, but which did, in the end, help the two sections to become one nation again . . . after a war whose bitterness might have seemed to make such a reunion wholly impossible. No part of either man's life became him more than the part he played in their brief meeting in the McLean house at Appomattox. Their behavior there put all succeeding generations of Americans in their debt. Two great Americans, Grant and Lee—very different, yet under everything very much alike. Their encounter at Appomattox was one of the great moments of American history.

Comparison Technique Questions

1. What is the writer comparing in the paragraph? Is there a topic sentence that clearly states the items for comparison? If not, write one for the paragraph.

2. What organizational pattern does the writer use, point-by-point or block?

3. Point out transitional expressions the writer uses to connect ideas and to add rhythm. Are there any that the writer could have used to achieve smooth transitions? If so, which ones and where would they be placed for greatest effectiveness?

4. Does the writer use enough specific examples to develop the comparison?

Suggestions for Writing

1. Write a paragraph comparing two moral, social, economic, or political disagreements that have been or might become conflicts.
2. Write a paragraph on why the two items you chose in Question 1 are so difficult to resolve. Concentrate on explaining, not taking either side or trying to persuade the reader to adopt a particular solution.

PRACTICE 11

Analyzing and Writing Contrast Paragraphs

Read All About It ...

To read the full essay from which this paragraph is excerpted, see page 455.

In the following paragraph from an essay, "Living on Tokyo Time," by Lynnika Butler, how the Japanese view time and how Americans view time is contrasted. Answer the questions following the paragraph.

A lot of Westerners make the glib assumption that Japanese people are simply submissive, unoriginal, or masochistic enough to put up with such a

punishing system. I don't think that's it. In Japan, time is measured in the same hours and minutes and days as anywhere else, but it is experienced as a fundamentally different phenomenon. In the West, we save time, spend time, invest time, even kill time—all of which implies that it belongs to us in the first place. We might find ourselves obliged to trade huge chunks of our time for a steady salary, but most of us resent this as something stolen from us, and we take it for granted that our spare hours are none of our teachers' or bosses' business.

Contrast Technique Questions

1. What organizational pattern does the writer use, point-by-point or block?

2. Does the author use any transitional expressions to move from point to point?

3. In the first sentence of the paragraph, exactly what ideas are being contrasted?

TOPIC BANK

Write a comparison or contrast paragraph about one or more of the following topics or about a topic of your own choice.

1. Two pieces of art
2. Two members of your family
3. Two magazines (see the photo on page 233)
4. Your past and present position on a social or political issue
5. Two schools you have attended
6. Two bosses or two coworkers
7. A widely held belief and its real meaning
8. Two places you have lived (cities, houses, countries)
9. Two forms of government (local, state, or national)
10. Two novels

WRITING OPPORTUNITIES



HOME The community council in your town has decided to raise funds by publishing and selling a book of recipes from local townspeople. Because you are known as the best dessert maker in the community, the committee has asked you to write a paragraph comparing the variety of uses of the blueberry versus the strawberry.

SCHOOL For your final exam in Home Economics 314, you had to make one dessert using blueberries and one dessert using strawberries. Additionally, you were instructed to write a paragraph comparing the two efforts.

WORK As communications director for the National Association of Fruit Growers, your current challenge is to put together a brochure extolling the virtues of people including a variety of fruits in their daily diet. Research indicates that most people think of blueberries and strawberries as dessert fruits only. Write a paragraph that makes a case for the blueberry and the strawberry as an “anytime food,” compared to apples, bananas, and oranges.



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Chapter Self-Assessment Test

Check either True or False on the blank next to the statement.

T	F	
_____	_____	Comparison and contrast assists the reader in understanding a person, place, or object to another.
_____	_____	Comparison and contrast does not consider feelings and ideas.
_____	_____	When comparing, you look for differences.
_____	_____	When contrasting, you look for similarities.
_____	_____	There are two commonly used organizational patterns for comparison and contrast paragraphs: point-by-point and block.
_____	_____	In comparison and contrast paragraphs, transitional expressions are important because they stress either comparison or contrast, depending on the type of paragraph being written.
_____	_____	Comparison and contrast paragraphs need to begin with a topic sentence that clearly states the items being compared or contrasted.
_____	_____	A topic sentence in a comparison or contrast paragraph does not have to state why the comparison or contrast is important.